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Executive positioning of EURO STOXX 50® CEOs and CFOs on LinkedIn: implications for financial communication

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Abstract

Purpose – Social media platforms such as LinkedIn have become crucial tools for corporate communication, enabling executives to engage directly with stakeholders. This study investigates how CEOs and CFOs of EURO STOXX 50® companies are positioned on LinkedIn, focusing on the alignment of their social media communication with their distinct organisational roles.

Design/methodology/approach – Based on 4,559 LinkedIn posts from 86 identified CEOs and CFOs over up to three years ending in December 2024, we use natural language processing (NLP) to train a bi-term topic model (BTM) to decode the social media narratives of selected EURO STOXX 50® C-level executives, identifying 14 distinct topics.

Findings – The study reveals a distinct positioning of CEOs and CFOs on LinkedIn. CEOs post more frequently, communicate on a broader range of strategic topics, and maintain year-round visibility, while CFOs focus more narrowly on financial topics and concentrate their activity around disclosure periods. Contrary to common assumptions, financial content – especially when shared by CFOs – generates higher engagement efficiency than visionary or strategic content.

Research limitations/implications – Despite the growing prevalence of executive communication on social media, this study focuses only on European firms, which might restrict its generalizability to other regional contexts. As a content analysis, it captures only the observable communication output of executives but not the underlying strategic decision-making processes.

Originality/value – This study enhances our understanding of how organisational roles inform executive positioning by revealing role-specific positioning strategies on LinkedIn. The study also highlights the complementary roles of the CEO and CFO as financial communicators. It provides actionable guidance for corporate communication and IR teams to align executive messaging with organ-isational objectives and stakeholder expectations.

Keywords Financial communication, Executive positioning, Investor relations, Social media, LinkedIn, Natural language processing, C-suite, CEO, CFO

Paper type Research article



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Introduction

Social media has evolved as a key channel for financial communication, enabling executives to engage directly with stakeholders (Troshani and Rowbottom, 2021). The use of social media for executive communications has been explored in various contexts, such as branding (Andreini *et al.*, 2021), social activism (Fröhlich and Knobloch, 2021), corporate social responsibility (CSR) communication (Wang and Huang, 2018), and employee engagement (Lee *et al.*, 2025). To date, few studies have examined how executives employ social media in the context of financial communication. In addition, most have focused on chief executive officers' (CEOs) use of social media (Fröhlich and Knobloch, 2021; Grafström and Falkman,

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2017; Lee *et al.*, 2025; Wu *et al.*, 2022; Wang and Huang, 2018). However, in the context of financial communication, the chief financial officer (CFO) also plays a major role in maintaining good stakeholder relationships (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025).

This study thus focuses on the role of social media – specifically LinkedIn – in positioning both the CEO and CFO, considering the specific context of financial communication. These two executive roles are regularly involved in financial disclosures, investor relations activities, and public-facing corporate messaging (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025; Binder-Tietz *et al.*, 2021). Selecting these roles allows for a theoretically grounded and empirically consistent comparison of executive communication, as they were present in all firms in the sample. Today, social media complements more traditional financial communication instruments, such as press releases, analyst calls and regulatory filings (Bollen *et al.*, 2008; Hoffmann and Strauß, 2024). Social media platforms such as LinkedIn provide corporate leaders with a new avenue to shape financial narratives, enhance transparency and build investor trust (Blankespoor *et al.*, 2014). Notably, LinkedIn is perceived as the most suitable social media platform for professional networking and content sharing in the corporate world. LinkedIn represents a strategic research context because it serves a dual purpose: (1) as a professional networking platform for personal branding and thought leadership, and (2) as a semi-public corporate communication channel used to reinforce organisational messaging. Executives' LinkedIn activity can therefore simultaneously reflect their individual identity as leaders and shape stakeholder perceptions of the company. This duality positions LinkedIn as a hybrid medium at the intersection of personal and corporate branding (Labrecque *et al.*, 2011; Blankespoor *et al.*, 2014), making it particularly relevant for analysing C-suite positioning in capital market communication. However, some argue that investors might be strongly sceptical regarding executives' self-promotion on such social media platforms (Chen *et al.*, 2013).

CEOs and CFOs fulfil distinct yet interrelated roles in corporate financial communication (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025). Whereas studies highlight that CEOs primarily communicate strategic direction, vision and long-term goals, CFOs focus on financial insights and investor relations (IR). However, capital market audiences pay close attention to, and frequently request direct interactions with, both the CEO and CFO (Hoffmann and Fieseler, 2012). Social media offers a unique platform where C-level executives can simultaneously communicate and reach a broad audience, tailoring their messages to different stakeholders.

When examining executive communications on social media, it is important to consider the concept of *positioning* (Zerfass *et al.*, 2016), as communication professionals play a key role in maintaining executives' social media presence. While most research on executive positioning again focuses on the CEO (Park and Berger, 2004; Davies and Chun, 2009; Eisenegger and Imhof, 2008), Hoffmann *et al.* (2025) highlight that the corporate communications and IR departments can be involved in positioning the CFO (Hoffmann and Strauß, 2024). In a study of European companies, Zerfass *et al.* (2016) found that although corporate communications departments are heavily involved in positioning the CEO, these efforts frequently lack a sound management process. Applying these insights to the use of LinkedIn by CEOs and CFOs, it is unclear whether these executives are positioned in distinct ways to address distinct audiences or topics in accordance with their respective management roles.

This study aims to fill the research gap on CEO and CFO positioning on social media by investigating the LinkedIn activity of chief officers of EURO STOXX 50® companies. Specifically, it addresses the guiding research question: How does the positioning of CEOs and CFOs on LinkedIn differ?

Literature review

Executive positioning, personal branding and the role of social media

Zerfass *et al.* (2016) define CEO *positioning* as a "specific communication strategy that uses both persuasive and collaborative communication activities to increase awareness of the

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highest representative of the organisation among all stakeholders and differentiate him or her from others in a credible way in the public sphere". Their large-scale survey study found that two-thirds of European companies actively positioned the CEO. In a study of German, Swiss and Austrian companies, Hoffmann *et al.* (2025) found that only half of the surveyed companies had defined a positioning strategy for chief officers, focused mostly on the CEO; however, 34% of the companies surveyed had defined a positioning strategy for both the CEO and CFO.

In the marketing literature, this phenomenon has been discussed in relation to the concept of *personal branding* (Khedher, 2014; Rangarajan *et al.*, 2017). Personal branding applies marketing concepts developed in the context of products and services to individuals, who develop a personal brand and market themselves through active communication (Khedher, 2014). In personal branding, the individual is associated with distinct brand attributes or values, and is actively positioned vis-à-vis target audiences (such as potential employers). Rangarajan *et al.* (2017) even argue that personal branding is unavoidable as each individual is associated with a personality, personal history or track record, communication style etc. Personal branding is especially relevant in the context of competitive human resources markets, such as elite sports, the arts, but also top management (Labrecque *et al.*, 2011). Khedher (2014) points out that the importance of personal branding has increased with the advent of social media, where users maintain personalized web presences and enjoy unprecedented opportunities to engage in self-promotional messaging.

Numerous studies examine the presence of executives – primarily the CEO – on social media based on content analyses. Analyses of X (formerly Twitter) indicate that CEOs in particular share insights to enhance their online influence and demonstrate leadership (Huang and Yeo, 2018). Chen *et al.* (2021) show that executives' personal branding on X can contribute to positive career outcomes. Rangarajan *et al.* (2017) point out that LinkedIn is especially amenable to personal branding as users highlight their experiences and achievements in a professional context.

Because most studies in this field are based on content analyses of publicly accessible accounts, they do not provide insights into how these social media presences are managed within companies. Personal branding is mostly described as the domain of the respective individual (Khedher, 2014; Rangarajan *et al.*, 2017). It can be somewhat haphazard and misdirected in the case of lay individuals (cf., Labrecque *et al.*, 2011). In a corporate context, however, communications departments are likely involved on how executives position themselves on social media. Zerfass *et al.* (2016) indicated that corporate communications departments play a major role in how CEOs address their audiences, while emphasising that executives' social media presence is not necessarily based on well-defined strategies or management processes. It is thus unclear whether distinct members of the executive board employ social media platforms such as LinkedIn in distinct ways to accord with their management roles and responsibilities. Before further elaborating CEOs' and CFOs' distinct roles, the next section will highlight the role of social media in the context of financial communication.

Financial communication on social media

Hoffmann and Strauß (2024) define financial communication as a communication function encompassing "(. . .) all communication activities carried out by a company or on its behalf that serve to maintain relations with financial stakeholders as well as important capital market intermediaries". Laskin and Hoffmann (2023) describe financial communication as a term that encompasses IR activities, although they highlight that IR officers might also communicate non-financial information. Furthermore, they suggest that other institutions also engage in financial communication, including governments when they address federal debt. Here, we focus on financial communication by listed companies.

The rise of social media has fundamentally changed how companies communicate with financial audiences, particularly in terms of financial disclosures and stakeholder engagement

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(Covello, 2021). Traditionally, offline formats such as annual general meetings, press releases or analyst calls have been used to channel financial communication (Bollen *et al.*, 2008). Social media has become a complementary platform for executives and companies to disseminate financial information and interact with various stakeholder groups, particularly investors (Blankespoor *et al.*, 2014). Most notably, the ability to engage in two-way communication, enabling direct feedback and real-time engagement, is considered a major asset of financial communication on social media (Cade, 2018).

With the advent of social media, financial communication increasingly encompasses instant, direct dialogue between companies and their financial audiences (Blankespoor *et al.*, 2014). Platforms such as X and LinkedIn are increasingly used to share earnings reports, strategic updates and investor-focused content, complementing traditional disclosure channels such as press releases and analyst calls (Blankespoor *et al.*, 2014). Social media enhances capital market engagement because posts by executives and companies can influence investor sentiment and even predict stock movements (Bollen *et al.*, 2011). However, using social media for financial communication also poses challenges. For instance, companies must ensure compliance with disclosure regulations (e.g. SEC Regulation FD) and maintain message consistency and accuracy in a fast-paced, informal environment (Laskin and Hoffmann, 2023).

CEO and CFO positioning on social media

To derive hypotheses on distinctions in CEO and CFO positioning in LinkedIn, we focus on their respective organisational roles. The CEO is considered the highest-ranking executive, responsible for setting the strategic direction and representing the company to both internal and external stakeholders (Finkelstein *et al.*, 2008). Consequently, the CEO's key role requires a high degree of visibility and proactive communication, often facilitated through platforms such as LinkedIn (Hambrick and Mason, 1984; Quigley and Hambrick, 2015). The CEO and CFO are perceived to be equally visible in the capital market (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025). However, CEOs are more involved in broader stakeholder relations, while CFOs are deeply involved in direct dialogue with investors (Binder-Tietz *et al.*, 2021).

Thus, CFOs tend to have a more restrained presence on social media platforms. From these distinct roles, we derive the following hypotheses:

H1a. CEOs post more frequently on LinkedIn than CFOs.

H1b. CEOs generate more engagement with their posts on LinkedIn than CFOs.

H2. Posts related to strategic topics generate higher engagement than financial topics.

In organisational theory and strategic management, CEOs' and CFOs' roles are traditionally defined by distinct responsibilities and areas of expertise. CEOs serve as the ultimate authority in setting the company's vision, long-term strategy and overarching corporate goals (Finkelstein *et al.*, 2008; Hambrick and Mason, 1984), acting as a strategic leader, often engaging in a wide array of topics (Conte *et al.*, 2017; Marais, 2012). By contrast, CFOs have a more narrowly defined scope focused on financial stewardship (Zorn, 2004; Hiebl, 2013), being primarily accountable for ensuring financial transparency and playing a key role in maintaining investor confidence by providing reliable financial information and performance metrics (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025).

This leads us to the following further hypotheses:

H3a. CEOs address a broad range of topics on LinkedIn, with a focus on strategy.

H3b. CFOs address a more concentrated range of topics on LinkedIn, with a focus on financials.

H4. CFOs address financial topics on LinkedIn more frequently than CEOs.

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CEO and CFO communication patterns differ not only in content but also in timing, closely linked to the structural responsibilities and expectations of each role. The CFO plays a central role in corporate financial reporting and is typically the key spokesperson during earnings announcements, quarterly reports and other financial disclosure events (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025). As the primary contact point for analysts, investors and financial media, the CFO's communication is often aligned with regulatory disclosure cycles (Graham *et al.*, 2005). Consequently, CFO activity on social media platforms such as LinkedIn is likely to cluster around these key reporting periods.

By contrast, the CEO is expected to represent the company in a broader, more continuous fashion (Conte *et al.*, 2017). The CEO's communication extends beyond financial disclosures, requiring an ongoing public presence, which is increasingly exercised through social media (Wu *et al.*, 2022). As a result, CEOs are more likely to engage in consistent, year-round communication activities, using platforms such as LinkedIn to maintain visibility and foster stakeholder engagement (Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025). These role-based distinctions inform the following hypotheses:

H5a. CEOs post on LinkedIn consistently throughout the year.

H5b. CFOs post on LinkedIn around key financial disclosures.

Method

In this chapter, we describe our methodological approach based on natural language processing (NLP). First, we collected the LinkedIn accounts of the EURO STOXX 50® CEOs and CFOs and analysed their posts. These two executive roles were selected because they represent the primary communicators in capital market contexts and were present in all companies of the index (with the exception of one recent appointment). This ensured consistency and comparability across firms. Second, we used bi-term topic modelling (BTM) for data analysis, which is particularly suitable for analysing short texts such as LinkedIn posts (Yan *et al.*, 2013).

The study focuses on the C-level of the EURO STOXX 50® – comprising 50 large, listed companies ("blue chips") from the eurozone and regarded as Europe's prime stock market barometer – with its composition frozen on 8 January 2025 (STOXX, 2025). As blue-chip companies, they are considered front-runners in terms of their financial communication practices. CEOs and CFOs were identified from the companies' corporate websites, and their LinkedIn accounts were manually detected using the four-eyes principle, thus complying with researcher triangulation (Flick, 2022). We verified each account based on three criteria: (1) consistency of job title and employer on the LinkedIn profile, (2) confirmation via the company website or press release, and (3) activity history matching the individual's tenure. This ensured the authenticity of the accounts.

Overall, 86 out of a possible 100 LinkedIn accounts of the 50 companies' CEOs and CFOs were identified. In the analysis of C-level activity on LinkedIn, 4,559 posts were collected over a period of up to three years ending in December 2024, retrieved from January to February 2025. Basic account information, self-disclosed personal information and engagement metrics were collected. For each executive, we included only posts published during their official term in office to avoid bias from predecessors' activity. If an executive had held the office for less than three years, posts were considered only from the start of their tenure; predecessors were not considered in such cases. To construct the corpus, we included only publicly visible posts that could influence engagement metrics, specifically (1) original posts and (2) reshared content with original commentary. Simple "likes" or shares without comment were excluded, as they do not contribute content authored by the executive and do not affect LinkedIn's engagement algorithm in a meaningful way. We included both original posts and reposted content with an original comment, keeping only those posts influencing the LinkedIn engagement algorithm on a personal level and acknowledging the significant role of

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dissemination in fostering stakeholder engagement. Because the executives come from companies across Europe, resulting in a multilingual sample, we used Google's translation API to standardise the content for evaluation in English (Human Science Co., Ltd, 2024). To gain unbiased and comprehensive insights, we deliberately refrained from applying exclusion criteria, such as setting a minimum number of followers.

For our text analysis, we extracted information from LinkedIn posts using NLP. Topic modelling eliminated the need to manually create a dictionary because the text naturally contains various topics that shape the word distribution, categorise the content and define the associated probabilities (Bellstam *et al.*, 2020; Frankel *et al.*, 2022). BTM is particularly suitable for analysing LinkedIn posts because it is based on word co-occurrence in short texts (Yan *et al.*, 2013). RStudio was used to perform the text analysis, with the data preparation conducted in accordance with Yan *et al.* (2013). First, words were converted into tokens and subsequently lemmatised. Next, stop words such as articles were removed, before cleaning less relevant tokens. Finally, statistically relevant collocations of two or more tokens were applied, aiding in noise reduction during subsequent model training while enhancing data clarity and precision.

The BTM relies on a specific number of topics (k) that most effectively explains the collected LinkedIn data. We calculated the optimal k-value through BTM iterations and evaluated it based on the estimation of the Akaike information criterion (AIC) and Perplexity (PPX) for k in 1:50 before training the model (Maibaum *et al.*, 2024).

$$AIC = 2\times k - 2\times \log\left(likelihood\right)$$

$$PPX = exp\left(-\frac{log\left(likelihood\right)}{Total\,Tokens}\right)$$

To select a suitable model, we calculated various k-statistics to determine the mathematical inflection points of our BTM. We used three methods to calculate the inflection points, as shown in Figure 1. The distance method (*dist*) identifies the point of greatest perpendicular

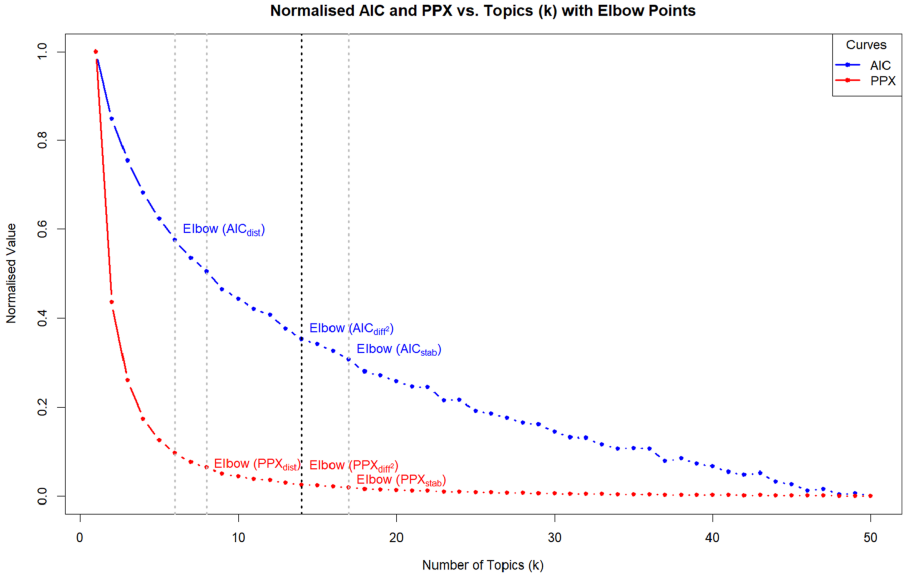


Figure 1. Elbow points of the BTM. Source: Authors' own work

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deviation from the straight line connecting the start and end points of the curve, indicating the most significant change in curvature. The stabilisation method (*stab*) detects the point at which the relative change first falls below a set threshold (e.g. 1%), signalling stabilisation. The second derivative ($diff^2$) highlights the point of greatest change in the rate of change, marking the transition from rapid to slower change. For AIC, the calculated elbow points are at $k = 6$ (*dist*), $k = 17$ (*stab*), and $k = 14$ ($diff^2$). For PPX, the elbow points are at $k = 8$ (*dist*), $k = 17$ (*stab*), and $k = 14$ ($diff^2$).

Based on the AIC_{diff^2} and PPX_{diff^2} elbows, we ultimately selected a model with 14 topics ($k = 14$), which not only is closest to the identified elbow points but also best describes the collected data approximating the optimum. The stabilisation method pinpoints where the curve flattens, indicating diminishing returns in model performance as complexity increases. This aligns with the principle of parsimony, ensuring that the model captures essential patterns without overfitting. The AIC inherently balances model fit and complexity, serving as a dependable criterion for optimal model selection. Therefore, we select a *k*-value that preserves essential data structures and interpretability while avoiding superfluous complexity by focusing on the second derivative elbow point of the normalised AIC curve.

With $k = 14$ selected via AIC and held-out PPX elbows, we trained a BTM on the full corpus. BTM infers themes from word co-occurrences in short posts (so there are no predefined topics) and returns, for each post, a topic-probability vector. Subsequent labelling was researcher-led via two-step triangulation: (1) ChatGPT-4o served as a lexical sparring partner on the top tokens by probabilities to suggest 2–3 candidate phrasings; (2) two authors independently reviewed tokens and high-probability example posts, refined or merged labels, and reached consensus among the research team. We additionally conducted a manual coherence/overlap check (semantic coherence, boundary clarity, redundancy) to mitigate overfitting. Lastly, Table 1 lists the top-10 tokens per topic for reader appraisal and robustness.

To assess topic diversity, we computed Shannon entropy (H) over mean topic probabilities for CEOs, CFOs and the full sample using natural logarithms (Shannon, 1948). Topic similarity was measured using Jensen–Shannon divergence (JSD), a symmetric variant of Kullback–Leibler divergence (KLD; Lin, 1991). Temporal communication patterns were analysed through weekly posting activity (Figure 5), comparisons of post shares during earnings seasons, and weekly-level Gini coefficients (e.g. Cowell, 2011) and entropy to capture concentration and diversity. Engagement differences across roles and content types were tested using independent sample *t*-tests on post-level metrics such as total engagement and engagement per follower. Posting frequency was assessed using time-adjusted post rates per executive, followed by group comparisons. Finally, we estimated two multiple linear regression models predicting engagement efficiency (Model I) and engagement reach (Model II), controlling for topic probabilities, company characteristics, content characteristics and executive background. All analyses were conducted in RStudio, with selected preprocessing performed in Excel. Further, selected code snippets for R were derived from using ChatGPT-4o as a coding partner.

Results

Prior to applying NLP to analyse the thematic content of our sample of CEOs' ($n = 3{,}552$; 77.8%) and CFOs' ($n = 1{,}014$; 22.2%) posts on LinkedIn, we conducted hashtag analysis to gain an overview and understanding of the self-identified priority topics. The distribution indicates a dominance of CEOs as executive voices on LinkedIn, reflecting their more active role on social media compared to CFOs. Hashtags are particularly useful for this overview because users must actively choose which topics to highlight in their posts, which can then be identified through LinkedIn's search function to participate in the discussion on selected topics. To reduce noise, we lemmatised the hashtags and focussed on the 100 most common hashtags by frequency, filtering out brands, company-related discussions, frequently used general terms that add no value to the understanding (e.g. "team"), and certain stop words (e.g. "of", "on" or "about").

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Table 1. Breakdown of the BTM and top ten token probabilities per topic

Topic (k)	t_1 (p)	t_2 (p)	t_3 (p)	t_4 (p)	t_5 (p)	t_6 (p)	t_7 (p)	t_8 (p)	t_9 (p)	t_{10} (p)
Research and Innovation Recognition (1)	award (0.01256)	research (0.00709)	innovation (0.00679)	company (0.00614)	international (0.00586)	support (0.00575)	project (0.00536)	woman (0.00523)	world (0.00503)	science (0.00495)
Climate Action and Sustainability Initiatives (2)	sustainable (0.01153)	sustainability (0.00971)	climate (0.00872)	emission (0.00844)	company (0.00816)	support (0.00725)	commitment (0.00710)	reduce (0.00696)	impact (0.00685)	global (0.00647)
Social Responsibility and Inclusive Workforce (3)	people (0.01543)	support (0.01128)	employee (0.00907)	commitment (0.00858)	community (0.00806)	world (0.00799)	value (0.00797)	create (0.00775)	company (0.00751)	diversity (0.00702)
Digital Transformation and Technological Solutions (4)	network (0.02613)	technology (0.01763)	customer (0.01513)	solution (0.01165)	digital (0.00994)	service (0.00930)	enable (0.00693)	business (0.00671)	deliver (0.00596)	innovation (0.00590)
Corporate Strategy and Business Growth (5)	solution (0.01727)	leader (0.00751)	plan (0.00689)	impact (0.00677)	pay (0.00664)	acquisition (0.00613)	grow (0.00574)	performance (0.00504)	site (0.00485)	client (0.00454)
Financial Performance and Capital Market Results (6)	result (0.01998)	growth (0.01873)	strong (0.01412)	continue (0.01382)	performance (0.01212)	increase (0.01007)	business (0.00985)	deliver (0.00957)	financial (0.00925)	customer (0.00885)
Crisis Response and Humanitarian Support (7)	support (0.02030)	people (0.01409)	employee (0.01151)	affect (0.01127)	colleague (0.00854)	provide (0.00830)	customer (0.00756)	family (0.00714)	ukraine (0.00703)	solidarity (0.00580)
Sustainable Energy and Renewable Fuel Production (8)	energy (0.01178)	hydrogen (0.01178)	production (0.01102)	project (0.00787)	site (0.00694)	technology (0.00657)	development (0.00655)	plant (0.00654)	reduce (0.00572)	industrial (0.00572)
Telecommunications and Network Expansion (9)	customer (0.01019)	network (0.00970)	company (0.00813)	example (0.00786)	digital (0.00717)	mobile (0.00700)	important (0.00575)	percent (0.00550)	phone (0.00484)	already (0.00458)
Global Economic Challenges and Risk Management (10)	challenge (0.01066)	world (0.00889)	global (0.00816)	business (0.00801)	risk (0.00760)	economic (0.00720)	company (0.00646)	people (0.00615)	change (0.00535)	Europe (0.00525)
Corporate Events and Executive Engagement (11)	colleague (0.01189)	opportunity (0.00839)	event (0.00760)	together (0.00752)	board (0.00709)	visit (0.00679)	ceo (0.00634)	company (0.00613)	talk (0.00550)	look_ forward (0.00548)
Market Growth and Innovation Strategy (12)	customer (0.01312)	business (0.01050)	company (0.00908)	innovation (0.00814)	technology (0.00779)	growth (0.00764)	continue (0.00734)	market (0.00725)	global (0.00692)	create (0.00684)
Sports Partnerships and Global Events (13)	game (0.01100)	sport (0.01030)	world (0.00973)	olympic (0.00967)	bring (0.00636)	paralympic (0.00606)	partner (0.00547)	people (0.00539)	athlete (0.00534)	support (0.00527)
Financial Reporting and Regulatory Compliance (14)	report (0.01077)	management (0.00931)	tax (0.00845)	business (0.00644)	cyber (0.00603)	topic (0.00600)	digital (0.00558)	important (0.00535)	career (0.00442)	security (0.00434)

Note(s): We considered the top ten tokens (t_n) ranked by their probability (p) per topic (k) based on the trained BTM. However, we used the top 25 tokens to derive the topic names

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In the first step, we found that the five most frequently used hashtags among CEOs were #sustainability ($n = 179$), #decarbonisation ($n = 157$), #digitalisation ($n = 118$), #technology ($n = 85$) and #result ($n = 83$), reflecting an emphasis on environmental responsibility, digital transformation and (financial) performance (see Figure 2). In terms of strategic communication, the prominence of performance-oriented terms (e.g. "result") might indicate a communicative bias towards financial stakeholders, possibly aimed at strengthening legitimacy and investor confidence rather than fostering an inclusive, multi-stakeholder dialogue on LinkedIn.

We identified the five most frequently used hashtags among CFOs as #finance ($n = 57$), #sustainability ($n = 45$), #result ($n = 26$), #financialresult ($n = 21$), and #esg ($n = 20$) (see Figure 3). Although this aligns with the expected commitment towards the dedicated role of finance, it also reflects a communicative alignment with CFOs' core functional responsibilities in financial stewardship, performance reporting and sustainability integration. The dominance of financial and results-oriented terminology suggests a continued focus on capital market expectations and accountability. Simultaneously, the presence of #sustainability and #esg suggests a growing imperative for CFOs to engage in broader narratives of CSR, despite potentially being framed through a financial lens favouring financial stakeholders' interests regarding the company's environmental, social and governance (ESG) performance.

To achieve a more comprehensive insight into the subjects discussed by executives on LinkedIn, we employed NLP – with a particular focus on BTM – to decode executives' communication by breaking it down into a singular topic model of EURO STOXX 50® CEO and CFO executive voices on LinkedIn encompassing 14 distinct topics (see Table 1) [1]. The topic names were jointly derived by the researchers utilising the top 25 tokens and their corresponding probabilities as a basis for decision-making [2]. Based on this topic model, we constructed a heatmap for each STOXX® supersector to visualise the divergence in the topical focus of CEOs and CFOs (see Figure 4). For each topic–sector cell, we plot the difference in average topic probability between CEOs and CFOs (i.e. CEO minus CFO). Warmer (red) shades indicate a stronger emphasis from CEOs, while cooler (blue) shades indicate a stronger emphasis from CFOs. The "All supersectors" column only includes those supersectors that



Figure 2. Word cloud of hashtags used by CEOs. Source: Authors' own work

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Figure 3. Word cloud of hashtags used by CFOs. Source: Authors' own work

meet our inclusion criteria, providing an overview of role-specific positioning while preserving sectoral nuances.

To test H1a, we compared CEOs' and CFOs' weekly posting frequency. On average, CEOs posted significantly more frequently ($\mu = 0.73$ posts per week, $s = 0.60$) than CFOs ($\mu = 0.14$, $s = 0.17$). A Welch two-sample *t*-test confirmed that this difference is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$). These findings and Figure 5 support H1a, indicating that CEOs were more active communicators on LinkedIn than CFOs during the observation period.

Table 2 reports the results of two regression models examining engagement efficiency (Model I: engagement per follower) and engagement reach (Model II: *log* engagement) on LinkedIn. Across both models, CEO and CFO posts differed significantly. Although CEOs generated lower engagement efficiency ($\beta = -0.041$, $p < 0.001$), they achieved substantially greater overall reach ($\beta = 0.628$, $p < 0.001$), even when controlling for follower count, topic probabilities, and company and content characteristics. The models demonstrate solid explanatory power, with $R^2 = 0.275$ for Model I and $R^2 = 0.573$ for Model II; the findings remain robust across different specifications. These findings indicate that CEOs might benefit from broader visibility, whereas CFOs maintain more targeted audience interactions. Thus, H1b is partly supported.

To test H2, we compared average engagement metrics between posts related to the derived topics, particularly strategic (Topics 1, 2, 4, 5, 8, 10 and 12) and financial topics (Topics 6, 12 and 14). Relative engagement (engmt.) was measured using total reactions, reposts, and comments per follower. To support this classification, we employed a binary coding approach categorising each topic as either financial and/or strategic using both the top ten most probable tokens per topic and the manually assigned topic descriptions. Topics were coded as "1" (indicated by "•" in Table 3) if they included at least one term from a predefined keyword list and the researchers decided accordingly (e.g. "revenue", "report", "tax" for financial; "strategy", "plan", "sustainability" for strategic), and "0" (indicated by a blank in Table 3) otherwise. Table 3 shows that total posts related to financial topics generated higher average engagement ($\mu = 0.0356$, $s = 0.0498$, $n = 1{,}343$) than non-financial topics ($\mu = 0.0193$, $s = 0.0385$, $n = 3{,}216$), thus not supporting H2. Additionally, although not the focus of H2,

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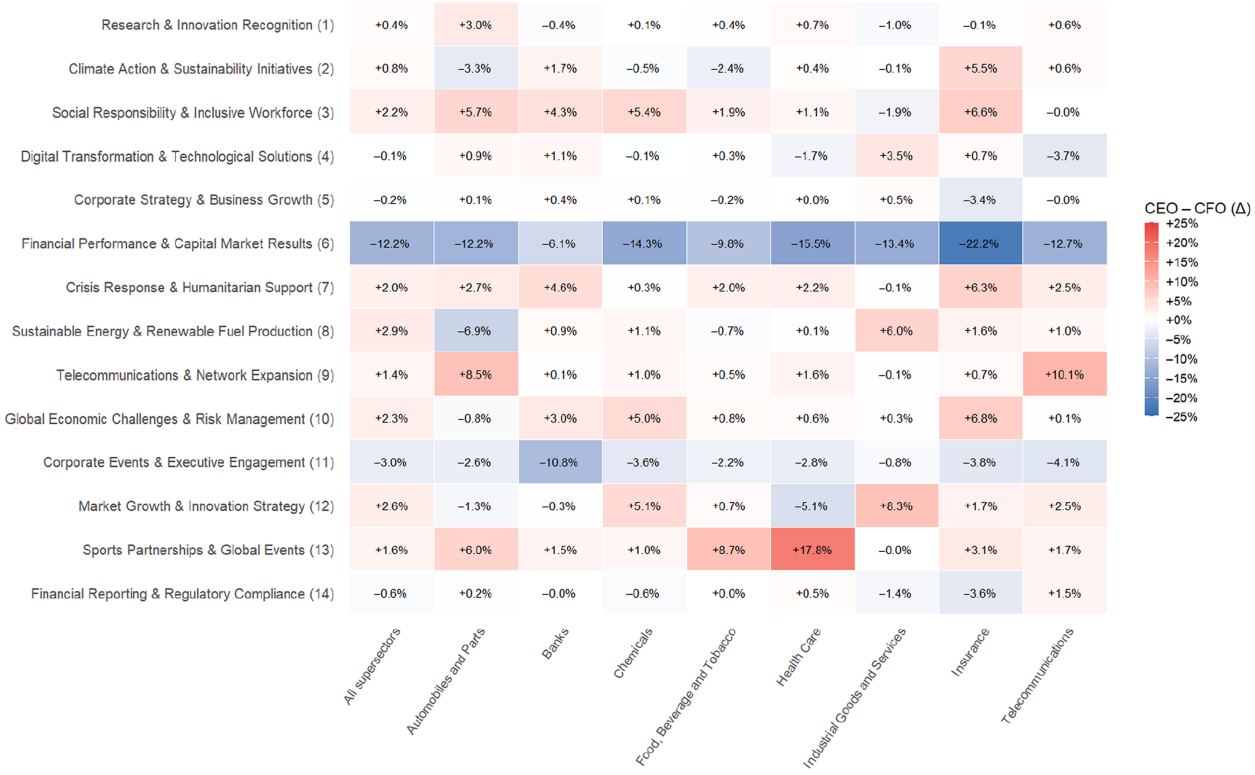


Figure 4. CEO–CFO topic probability divergence matrix by STOXX® supersector [3]. Source: Authors' own work

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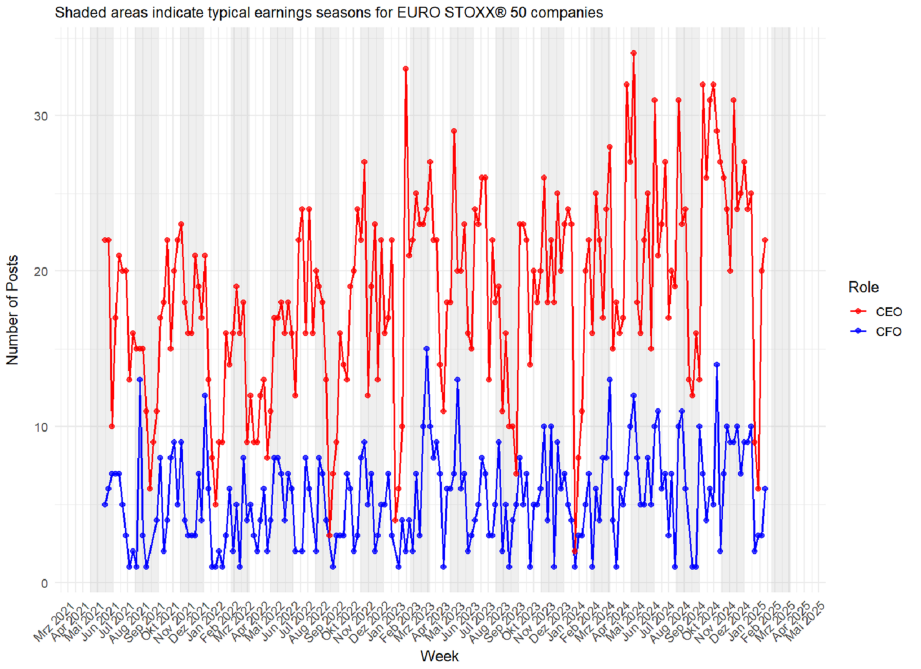


Figure 5. Weekly LinkedIn posts by executive role. Source: Authors' own work

total posts categorised as strategic ($\mu = 0.0208$, $s = 0.0388$, $n = 2{,}295$) showed slightly lower engagement than non-strategic posts ($\mu = 0.0275$, $s = 0.0462$, $n = 2{,}264$), suggesting that strategic framing alone might not be associated with higher follower interaction. A Welch two-sample *t*-test confirmed that both differences are statistically significant ($p < 0.001$).

To assess topic diversity in executives' LinkedIn communications, we calculated Shannon entropy based on the average topic probabilities per group. The result was higher for CEOs ($H = 2.47$) than for CFOs ($H = 2.36$), indicating that CEOs tend to communicate across a broader range of topics and thus supporting H3a. We computed the Jensen–Shannon divergence (JSD = 0.021) between the two distributions of groups to evaluate differences in thematic focus. This low value suggests largely similar, yet not identical, topic preferences of executive voices on LinkedIn. Notably, whereas Topic 6 ("Financial Performance and Capital Market Results") dominated CFO communication – consistent with H3b – Topic 12 ("Market Growth and Innovation Strategy") emerged as the most prominent topic among CEOs, further reinforcing their strategic focus and supporting H3a. These results are robust when concentrating on the main topics (by highest probability) per post (see Table 3), as well as comparing them with the hashtags used by CEOs (see Figure 2) and CFOs (see Figure 3).

Further, according to Table 3, CFOs dedicated 41.2% of their posts to financial topics (Topics 6, 12 and 14), compared to only 26.1% of CEOs' posts. A chi-squared test confirms that this difference is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), providing clear support for H4.

Figure 5 visualises the weekly LinkedIn activity of CEOs and CFOs. Whereas CEO posts appear more evenly distributed across the year, CFO activity shows seasonal peaks that align with earnings reporting windows, suggesting a communicative bias towards event-driven communication. This pattern offers initial support for H5a and H5b. To validate this, we compared the share of posts published during earnings seasons, with 48.9% for CEOs and 50.6% for CFOs. CEOs also showed a lower Gini coefficient (0.196) and higher Shannon entropy (5.19), indicating a more even and diversified posting pattern. By contrast, CFOs

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Table 2. Regression analysis of executive engagement on LinkedIn

Variable	Model I: Engagement efficiency (engagement per Follower) Coefficient	Std. err.	*t*-value	*p*-value	[95% conf. Interval]		Model II: Engagement reach (engagement (log)) Coefficient	Std. err.	*t*-value	*p*-value	[95% conf. Interval]	
Executive characteristics												
CEO Role (yes/no)	−0.041	0.002	−22.990	0.000***	−0.045	−0.038	0.628	0.058	10.908	0.000***	0.515	0.741
(Intercept)	0.098	0.016	6.156	0.000***	0.067	0.130	1.372	0.346	3.959	0.000***	0.692	2.051
Followers (*log*)	–	–	–	–	–	–	0.314	0.019	16.506	0.000***	0.277	0.351
Executive Compensation (EUR)	0.000	0.000	2.723	0.006**	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.913	0.361	0.000	0.000
Board Experience (years)	0.001	0.000	9.909	0.000***	0.001	0.002	−0.002	0.003	−0.630	0.529	−0.007	0.004
Tenure in Current Role (years)	−0.003	0.000	−10.863	0.000***	−0.003	−0.002	−0.014	0.006	−2.549	0.011*	−0.025	−0.003
Thematical characteristics												
Research and Innovation Recognition (1)	0.021	0.014	1.486	0.137	−0.007	0.049	0.079	0.290	0.273	0.785	−0.489	0.647
Climate Action and Sustainability Initiatives (2)	0.006	0.014	0.439	0.661	−0.021	0.034	−0.475	0.283	−1.676	0.094†	−1.030	0.081
Social Responsibility and Inclusive Workforce (3)	0.023	0.013	1.741	0.082†	−0.003	0.048	0.012	0.262	0.047	0.963	−0.502	0.526
Digital Transformation and Technological Solutions (4)	0.035	0.014	2.543	0.011*	0.008	0.062	0.120	0.280	0.430	0.667	−0.428	0.669
Corporate Strategy and Business Growth (5)	0.013	0.018	0.703	0.482	−0.023	0.049	0.029	0.371	0.079	0.937	−0.699	0.757
Financial Performance and Capital Market Results (6)	0.077	0.012	6.711	0.000***	0.055	0.100	1.667	0.233	7.145	0.000***	1.210	2.125
Crisis Response and Humanitarian Support (7)	0.048	0.013	3.630	0.000***	0.022	0.073	0.845	0.266	3.172	0.002**	0.323	1.367
Sustainable Energy and Renewable Fuel Production (8)	0.039	0.014	2.837	0.005**	0.012	0.065	0.446	0.277	1.612	0.107	−0.096	0.988
Telecommunications and Network Expansion (9)	0.017	0.013	1.251	0.211	−0.009	0.043	0.137	0.270	0.506	0.613	−0.393	0.666
Global Economic Challenges and Risk Management (10)	0.004	0.015	0.245	0.806	−0.025	0.032	−0.402	0.294	−1.366	0.172	−0.978	0.175
Corporate Events and Executive Engagement (11)	0.015	0.013	1.166	0.244	−0.010	0.040	0.252	0.258	0.974	0.330	−0.255	0.758
Market Growth and Innovation Strategy (12)	0.024	0.013	1.909	0.056†	−0.001	0.050	0.708	0.259	2.731	0.006**	0.200	1.217
Sports Partnerships and Global Events (13)	0.028	0.013	2.216	0.027*	0.003	0.053	0.653	0.258	2.535	0.011*	0.148	1.158

(*continued*)

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Table 2. Continued

Variable	Model I: Engagement efficiency (engagement per Follower) Coefficient	Std. err.	*t*-value	*p*-value	[95% conf. Interval]		Model II: Engagement reach (engagement (log)) Coefficient	Std. err.	*t*-value	*p*-value	[95% conf. Interval]	
Financial Reporting and Regulatory Compliance (14)	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Company characteristics												
Controversy Score (avg. 2021–2024)	0.000	0.000	3.936	0.000***	0.000	0.000	−0.001	0.001	−0.680	0.497	−0.002	0.001
Workforce Score (avg. 2021–2024)	−0.001	0.000	−7.627	0.000***	−0.001	0.000	0.012	0.002	7.885	0.000***	0.009	0.015
Management Score (avg. 2021–2024)	0.000	0.000	2.295	0.022*	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.001	0.227	0.820	−0.002	0.002
Market Capitalisation (avg. 2021–2024)	0.000	0.000	−12.683	0.000***	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	−2.975	0.003**	0.000	0.000
Employee Count (avg. 2021–2024)	0.000	0.000	−4.251	0.000***	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	4.772	0.000***	0.000	0.000
Operating Profit Margin (avg. 2021–2024)	0.000	0.000	−1.717	0.086†	0.000	0.000	0.014	0.002	6.461	0.000***	0.010	0.018
Return on Equity (avg. 2021–2024)	0.001	0.000	3.946	0.000***	0.000	0.001	−0.008	0.003	−3.100	0.002**	−0.013	−0.003
Debt-to-Capital Ratio (avg. 2021–2024)	−0.001	0.000	−11.202	0.000***	−0.001	−0.001	−0.008	0.001	−5.987	0.000***	−0.011	−0.006
Total Capital (avg. 2021–2024)	0.000	0.000	14.335	0.000***	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	3.312	0.001***	0.000	0.000
Content characteristics												
Text Length (character count)	0.000	0.000	4.532	0.000***	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	5.491	0.000***	0.000	0.000
Non-English Post (yes/no)	0.000	0.002	0.069	0.945	−0.003	0.003	−0.245	0.032	−7.643	0.000***	−0.308	−0.182
Reposted (yes/no)	−0.021	0.002	−13.007	0.000	−0.024	−0.018	−1.181	0.033	−36.221	0.000***	−1.245	−1.117
Hashtags Used (yes/no)	0.000	0.001	−0.048	0.961	−0.003	0.003	−0.119	0.027	−4.397	0.000***	−0.173	−0.066
Tagged Accounts (yes/no)	0.001	0.001	0.429	0.668	−0.002	0.003	0.057	0.029	1.984	0.047*	0.001	0.113
Image Included (yes/no)	0.003	0.001	2.288	0.022*	0.000	0.006	0.259	0.030	8.535	0.000***	0.200	0.319
Video Included (yes/no)	0.001	0.002	0.849	0.396	−0.002	0.005	0.243	0.036	6.803	0.000***	0.173	0.313

Note(s): Model I analyses engagement efficiency (engagement per follower), whereas Model II captures engagement reach (engagement (*log*)). Observations (n) = 4,559 for both models. CEO Role is a binary indicator (1 = CEO, 0 = CFO), with CFOs serving as the reference category (refer to (Intercept)). Model I: $R^2 = 0.275$, RMSE = 0.04. Model II: $R^2 = 0.573$, RMSE = 0.74. $^{\dagger}p < 0.10$, $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$

Source(s): Authors' own work

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Table 3. Breakdown of the BTM by main topics and relative engagement metrics

			CEO					CFO					Total				
Topic (*k*)	Strategic	Financial	Obs.	Engmt. per Follower (Mean (μ))	Engmt. per Follower (SD(*s*))	Engmt. per Follower (Min)	Engmt. per Follower (Max)	Obs.	Engmt. per Follower (Mean (μ))	Engmt. per Follower (SD(*s*))	Engmt. per Follower (Min)	Engmt. per Follower (Max)	Obs.	Engmt. per Follower (Mean (μ))	Engmt. per Follower (SD(*s*))	Engmt. per Follower (Min)	Engmt. per Follower (Max)
1	•		126	0.0116	0.0179	0.0002	0.1260	34	0.0474	0.0774	0.0018	0.3427	160	0.0192	0.0414	0.0002	0.3427
2	•		270	0.0123	0.0161	0.0005	0.1416	101	0.0259	0.0294	0.0022	0.2253	371	0.0160	0.0214	0.0005	0.2253
3			378	0.0120	0.0157	0.0003	0.1734	81	0.0459	0.0563	0.0041	0.3629	459	0.0180	0.0304	0.0003	0.3629
4	•		284	0.0086	0.0130	0.0005	0.0897	51	0.1049	0.1586	0.0004	0.6579	335	0.0233	0.0715	0.0004	0.6579
5	•		26	0.0179	0.0127	0.0016	0.0576	9	0.0575	0.0485	0.0056	0.1296	35	0.0281	0.0313	0.0016	0.1296
6		•	308	0.0260	0.0281	0.0008	0.1819	268	0.0839	0.0783	0.0039	0.5407	576	0.0529	0.0640	0.0008	0.5407
7			146	0.0216	0.0644	0.0002	0.7303	3	0.0110	0.0104	0.0016	0.0221	149	0.0214	0.0638	0.0002	0.7303
8	•		252	0.0263	0.0282	0.0006	0.1493	55	0.0315	0.0720	0.0020	0.4951	307	0.0272	0.0396	0.0006	0.4951
9			224	0.0068	0.0057	0.0008	0.0340	6	0.0170	0.0149	0.0029	0.0404	230	0.0071	0.0062	0.0008	0.0404
10	•		317	0.0102	0.0129	0.0005	0.0946	51	0.0286	0.0209	0.0007	0.1010	368	0.0128	0.0156	0.0005	0.1010
11			359	0.0139	0.0134	0.0002	0.0823	167	0.0441	0.0570	0.0023	0.4900	526	0.0235	0.0367	0.0002	0.4900
12	•	•	585	0.0193	0.0250	0.0002	0.2519	134	0.0414	0.0417	0.0007	0.3230	719	0.0234	0.0301	0.0002	0.3230
13			239	0.0179	0.0175	0.0004	0.1315	37	0.0416	0.0471	0.0039	0.2270	276	0.0211	0.0249	0.0004	0.2270
14		•	34	0.0069	0.0059	0.0015	0.0285	14	0.0235	0.0249	0.0013	0.0793	48	0.0118	0.0159	0.0013	0.0793
Total			3,548	0.0157	0.0237	0.0002	0.7303	1,011	0.0538	0.0717	0.0004	0.6579	4,559	0.0241	0.0428	0.0002	0.7303
Thereof Strategic			1,860	0.0155	0.0213	0.0002	0.2519	435	0.0433	0.0734	0.0004	0.6579	2,295	0.0208	0.0388	0.0002	0.6579
Thereof Non-Strategic			1,688	0.0158	0.0261	0.0002	0.7303	576	0.0617	0.0695	0.0013	0.5407	2,264	0.0275	0.0462	0.0002	0.7303
Thereof Financial			927	0.0211	0.0260	0.0002	0.2519	416	0.0682	0.0705	0.0007	0.5407	1,343	0.0356	0.0498	0.0002	0.5407
Thereof Non-Financial			2,621	0.0138	0.0225	0.0002	0.7303	595	0.0438	0.0709	0.0004	0.6579	3,216	0.0193	0.0385	0.0002	0.7303

Note(s): We focused exclusively on posts or reposts with original content from the selected executives to ensure that the engagement (engmt.) data is directly relevant to our sample following LinkedIn's engagement algorithm. Further, engagement per follower refers to the ratio of total engagement (the total of reactions, comments and reposts) to the number of followers per executive per post. Mean (μ), standard deviation (SD, *s*), minimum (Min), and maximum (Max) are calculated per subgroup. The number of observations (obs.) reflects both the number of main topics assigned to each post based on the highest topic probability and the total number of posts categorised under each topic. Topic categorisation into "strategic" and "financial" was based on a binary keyword-matching approach using each topic's top ten tokens and its assigned descriptive label

Source(s): Authors' own work

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exhibited a higher Gini (0.342) and slightly lower entropy (5.06), reflecting more concentrated communication. Taken together, these results provide support for both H5a and H5b.

Discussion and conclusions

This study contributes to the growing body of research on executive communication in digital environments by examining how CEOs and CFOs from EURO STOXX 50® companies are positioned on LinkedIn, specifically in the context of financial communication. It offers a novel framework for understanding how executives perform their institutional identities on social media by integrating organisational role theory with digital communication analysis. It demonstrates that digital platforms are arenas for role performance and stakeholder alignment –thus advancing interdisciplinary theory at the intersection of organisational behaviour and strategic communication.

Theoretical contributions

First, this study adds to previous research on CEO positioning (Zerfass *et al.*, 2016) by demonstrating how executive positioning manifests differently for CEOs and CFOs on LinkedIn. It highlights not only that executive roles are reflected in organisational practice but also that distinct organisational roles translate into distinct social media communication patterns. Current frameworks of CEO positioning, thus, need to be extended from (a) incorporating additional members of the executive team, and (b) accounting for the distinct requirements of various executive roles. From the perspective of the personal branding literature (Khedher, 2014; Labrecque *et al.*, 2011), CEO and CFO brands appear to differ systematically. No frameworks for executives' personal branding accounting for distinct organisational roles yet exist.

Second, this study empirically confirms and deepens theoretical assumptions about CEOs' and CFOs' distinct communicative roles. Whereas CEOs predominantly engage with forward-looking, strategic themes such as innovation, sustainability and digital transformation (Finkelstein *et al.*, 2008), CFOs focus on financial stewardship, reporting and regulatory compliance (Tulimieri and Banai, 2010; Zorn, 2004). The findings also add to previous literature on CEOs' and CFOs' communicative role by highlighting that both also address overlapping topics. Sustainability, especially, emerges as a key topic for both CEOs and CFOs, indicating its cross-functional relevance in executive communication. These findings challenge role theory perspectives in executive communication research as current frameworks need to account for shared responsibilities and the increasing need for CFOs to be able to address topics traditionally deemed the domain of the CEO.

Third, contrary to previous assumptions that visionary content drives the most engagement (Hambrick and Mason, 1984; Quigley and Hambrick, 2015), this study reveals that financial content – especially when shared by CFOs – elicits disproportionately high levels of interaction per follower. This challenges and refines existing theories of social media engagement by emphasising that relevance to stakeholders might be a stronger driver than thematic positioning or brand-level storytelling. However, there are mechanisms likely explaining why financial topics outperform strategic ones on engagement efficiency basis. First, platform–audience fit on LinkedIn potentially rewards informational utility as a professional and expert social network (e.g. by using results, guidance, reporting etc.) over visionary framing, which could be especially true around disclosure windows. Second, role–message congruence means CFO-authored financial posts are perceived as more credible or relevant by their mostly financially oriented followers (higher audience fit compared to a more general audience of CEOs) (from a marketing perspective see, e.g. Belanche *et al.*, 2021). In addition, engagement efficiency typically declines with audience size (micro tend to outperform macro influencers) (e.g. Kay *et al.*, 2020), and CEOs' larger followings can mechanically depress rates relative to CFOs (see follower counts in Appendix Tables).

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Together, these factors help explaining the refutation of H2 despite CEOs' greater overall reach.

Fourth, the findings broaden the scope of financial communication theory by demonstrating that LinkedIn functions as a hybrid channel merging traditional IR with corporate storytelling and executive personal branding (Blankespoor *et al.*, 2014; Rangarajan *et al.*, 2017). The findings highlight how CFOs increasingly utilise social media to communicate complex financial narratives in accessible formats, thereby creating new discursive practices within the financial communication domain. This challenges studies arguing that social media play a marginal role in the context of financial communication (Hoffmann and Binder-Tietz, 2021). This assumption may not hold when considering the highly personalized context of executive communication vis-à-vis financial audiences.

Fifth, whereas much existing literature focuses on CEO visibility (Fröhlich and Knobloch, 2021; Grafström and Falkman, 2017; Lee *et al.*, 2025; Wu *et al.*, 2022; Wang and Huang, 2018), this study brings the CFO to the fore, offering both theoretical justification and empirical evidence for their expanding role in digital financial communication. It contributes to a more balanced perspective in executive communication research and underscores the CFO's strategic importance in shaping financial narratives on public platforms (cf., Hoffmann *et al.*, 2025).

Finally, beyond individual communication patterns, the study also invites reflection on the broader social implications of executive presence on social media. As CEOs and CFOs engage with stakeholders in digital spaces, their visibility contributes not only to corporate messaging but also to perceptions of leadership authenticity and trustworthiness. Such digital activity can reinforce, or in some cases, challenge organisational legitimacy in the eyes of investors, employees, and the broader public. These dynamics link executive communication to wider societal expectations around transparency, accountability, and corporate responsibility. Particularly in the case of CFOs, increased online visibility signals a shift toward more dialogical and stakeholder-oriented financial communication. This development aligns with current debates on digital leadership identities and the performative nature of executive roles in public online arenas (Labrecque *et al.*, 2011; Zerfass *et al.*, 2016).

Practical implications

The findings underscore the critical significance of aligning executive positioning strategy on social media with CEOs' and CFOs' functional responsibilities and symbolic roles. Top executives' positioning on LinkedIn is therefore not merely an extension of their personal voice but rather a strategic function that the company's communications department must guide. Although the IR and corporate communications departments are likely to be involved, our findings suggest that a shared responsibility model is necessary, with corporate communications taking the lead on narrative development and consistency while IR ensures alignment with market-relevant messaging and financial transparency.

To ensure actionability, we translate the results into five concise best practices: (1) Investor relations: prioritise CFO-authored financial posts around disclosure windows to maximise engagement per follower; apply the executional levers indicated by Table 2, notably use original posts (not reshares), images or videos, English language only, and concrete, specific wording. (2) Corporate communications: maintain an always-on CEO cadence to drive reach; interleave strategic themes (e.g. topics 2, 4 and 12) with concise performance cues; minimise reshares and support key messages with a single clear visual (Table 2). (3) Executive office or chief of staff: set role-specific KPIs (CEO = overall reach; CFO = efficiency among key financial stakeholders); sequence content (CFO concentrates on financial results; CEO on strategic vision and implications) and stagger posts on reporting days to avoid internal cannibalisation (Figure 5). (4) Sector-sensitive playbook: use the divergence matrix (Figure 4) as a benchmark and baseline to calibrate which role leads on which topics. (5) Measurement and governance: track both engagement efficiency and reach in dashboards; review the role

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split and thematic focus on a quarterly basis (e.g. by using a divergence matrix) and anchor the calendar on CFO disclosure events, while scheduling CEO content year-round.

Therefore, CFOs' activities on LinkedIn should be supported primarily by IR teams, especially around the publication of critical financial data or events where credibility and clarity are crucial. Nevertheless, the corporate communications department should assist in extending CFOs' narratives – particularly in adjacent areas such as ESG reporting, compliance or governance – to underpin the finance function's expanding role in stakeholder communication. Conversely, corporate communications should manage CEOs' communications, especially considering a broad, cross-stakeholder perspective including strategy, corporate vision and long-term transformational goals. CEO positioning is fundamentally strategic and thus reaches internal and external constituencies. Effective CEO communication should combine structured planning with sufficient flexibility to respond to real-time developments while maintaining authenticity across content topics. CEOs can cultivate legitimacy among different audiences by combining strategic narratives, such as innovation or transformation, with performance-oriented messages. Given that ensuring consistency and thematic depth enhances the effectiveness of strategic communication and broadens stakeholder engagement, organisations should establish governance frameworks that define ownership, coordination and performance evaluation for executive social media communication. This includes content planning in line with the corporate calendar, as well as monitoring engagement.

Limitations, future research directions and conclusion

Our study is subject to several limitations. First, because the EURO STOXX 50® sample refers to developed capital markets in the eurozone, our results might not be transferable to emerging capital markets or non-European contexts where executive communication via social media is less prevalent. Second, the sole focus on CEOs and CFOs excludes other influential members of the executive suite whose communication behaviours could reveal complementary dynamics despite their subordinate roles in strategic and financial communication. Future research could focus on the use of cross-CXO samples to shed light on a collective executive positioning approach and intra-executive dynamics, with a particularly keen focus on the chief strategy officer (CSO), whose role is becoming increasingly important in sustainability reporting. Third, the cross-country perspective of EURO STOXX 50® has a cross-country perspective in Europe, which required a systematic translation of the text analysis. Future studies could therefore focus on monolingual (e.g. anglophone) regions to reduce translation noise. Finally, our research is based exclusively on LinkedIn as a platform for corporate communication on social media; future studies could also explore other social media platforms (such as X) or even adopt a cross-platform approach to gain a broader understanding. Future research could also include qualitative methods, such as interviews with executives or surveys with stakeholders, to uncover the motivational drivers behind digital executive communication and perceptions of authenticity. These approaches could be complemented by analyses of how the frequency, tone, and content of executive posts shape stakeholder trust, influence perceptions of organisational legitimacy, or serve as strategic signals, particularly in contexts of reputational risk or corporate transformation.

Moreover, while our study identifies role-based thematic differences in executives' LinkedIn communication, it does not qualitatively examine how these themes are operationalised in specific marketing and stakeholder engagement practices. A deeper qualitative analysis (e.g. of narrative or linguistic style, visual elements, or stakeholder targeting in individual posts) would provide richer insight but lies beyond the scope of the present study due to methodological focus and word-count constraints. We consider this an important avenue for future research to extend the practical applicability of our findings.This study advances the discussion on executive communication on social media by articulating how CEOs and CFOs are positioned on LinkedIn, specifically for financial communication.

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We provide actionable guidance for practitioners and scholars to address the need for tailored and individual positioning of the C-suite on social media. As digital communication channels continue to evolve, scholars and practitioners must embrace multi-platform and multi-role perspectives to fully capture the complex landscape of executive communication on social media.

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Appendix

Table A1. Top ten CEOs of EURO STOXX 50® on LinkedIn (sorted by followers)

No.	Name	Company	Country	Followers	Trending main topics *k* (*n*)	Posts (*n*)	Engagement	Engmt. per post
1	Patrick Pouyanné	TOTAL	France	377,749	8(7); 3(5); 2(3)	19	43,764	2,303
2	Ola Källenius	MERCEDES-BENZ	Germany	318,724	9(23); 13 (16); 11 (7)	60	167,058	2,784
3	Christian Klein	SAP	Germany	264,936	11(97); 10 (55); 12 (50)	322	731,538	2,272
4	Fabricio Bloisi	PROSUS	Netherlands	262,505	12(44); 11 (15); 1 (10)	89	57,356	644
5	Roland Busch	SIEMENS	Germany	220,308	12(75); 4 (53); 8 (38)	292	468,129	1,603
6	Paul Hudson	SANOFI	France	204,446	13(27); 12 (21); 3(6)	60	197,088	3,285
7	Nicolas Hieronimus	L'OREAL	France	158,283	3(46); 12 (30); 11 (16)	151	251,532	1,666
8	Thomas Buberl	AXA	France	151,493	3(51); 10 (40); 2 (36)	246	227,232	924
9	Timotheus Höttges	DEUTSCHE TELEKOM	Germany	147,740	9(183); 11 (33); 7 (32)	381	328,078	861
10	Bill Anderson	BAYER	Germany	111,321	13(13); 11 (8); 3/7/ 12(5)	47	86,712	1,845
Mean (μ) Whole CEO Dataset				77,426		81	98,606	1,114

Source(s): Authors' own work

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Table A2. Top ten CFOs of EURO STOXX 50® on LinkedIn (sorted by followers)

No.	Name	Company	Country	Followers	Trending main topics *k* (*n*)	Posts (*n*)	Engagement	Engmt. per post
1	Arno Antlitz	VOLKSWAGEN	Germany	37,022	6(26); 12 (18); 8 (17)	79	57,470	727
2	Steedhar N.	SAINT GOBAIN	France	16,204	6(23); 12 (18); 8(5)	60	40,966	683
3	Stefano De Angelis	ENEL	Italy	14,668	6(18); 2 (4); 12(4)	32	11,987	375
4	Christophe Babule	L'OREAL	France	13,491	2(30); 3 (25); 1/6 (9)	104	29,673	285
5	Juergen Esser	DANONE	France	12,109	12(20); 6 (16); 2 (15)	70	30,990	443
6	Wolfgang Nickl	BAYER	Germany	10,202	6(14); 11 (10); 12 (10)	52	18,954	365
7	Hilary Maxson	SCHNEIDER ELECTRIC	France	10,105	3(11); 11 (9); 2/12 (7)	48	22,017	459
8	Melanie Kreis	DEUTSCHE POST	Germany	9,935	6(15); 3 (7); 10(4)	37	30,103	814
9	Dominik Asam	SAP	Germany	9,586	6(7); 12 (1)	8	8,718	1,090
10	Lars Machenil	BNP PARIBAS	France	9,298	11(45); 6 (16); 12 (9)	89	22,538	253
Mean (μ) Whole CFO Dataset				5,512		24	9,380	267

Source(s): Authors' own work

Notes

1. We used a singular topic model to ensure comparability between CEOs and CFOs within a shared semantic space to identify divergence or convergence in their communication on LinkedIn. This choice is further supported by the partially overlapping hashtag usage, suggesting a common thematic foundation across roles in the subsequent analysis.
2. Researcher triangulation was used to avoid biased reasoning.
3. Figure 4 shows a CEO–CFO divergence matrix by STOXX® supersectors. Each cell reports the difference in mean topic probability between CEOs and CFOs in percentage points (CEO minus CFO). Computation proceeds in two steps: (1) for every executive, topic probabilities are averaged across all of their posts; (2) these executive-level means are then averaged within each supersector and role. Positive values indicate stronger CEO dominance; negative values indicate stronger CFO dominance. Executives are included only if they published at least one public LinkedIn post during the observation window. Supersectors with fewer than two CEOs and two CFOs meeting this criterion are excluded; the "All supersectors" column pools only the supersectors that meet the inclusion rule. Values are shown to one decimal place; the colour scale is centred at zero and fixed at ± 25 percentage points (%).

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